

Grammar Worksheet – Articles

Use indefinite article *a / an*

- when first describing something, or making a general statement about something not known or without any details. Use *an* when the word following begins with a vowel.

*Suddenly **a man** appeared outside the window.*

*That is **an interesting** point.*

- to give an example.
***A thermometer** is used for measuring temperature.*
- to describe one of a class of things or people.
*Paula is **an Italian**. She's **a teacher**.*
*It's **a racing bike**.*
- for rates and speeds etc.
*Some people can cycle at **50 km an hour**.*
*Phil earns **€500 a month**.*

Use definite article *the*

- with things or people already mentioned.
*First, I take a test tube. Then into **the** test tube I pour 50 cc of water.*
- when a noun is made definite by details following it.
*That man outside was **the man that the police were looking for**.*
- when we definitely know what is being talked about.
*Are you going to **the post office**? Can you get me some stamps?*
*Pass me **the salt**, please.*

Use zero article

- to describe something general or uncountable.
***Love** makes the world go round. **Water** boils at 100°C.*
*Some people believe that **men** and **women** think differently.*
- with proper names, though these can begin with *the* if they have details following them.
***Kate** lives in **Manchester** in a little street called **Green Street**.*
*This is **Mary Smith**. She is **the Mary Smith** I told you about.*
- with general examples, countable or uncountable.
***Doctors** often have to work more than a hundred hours a week.*
***Water** is a scarce resource in many parts of the world.*

Note that article use depends on context. **Unit 30** contains more examples of how to use *a / an*, *the* and zero article.

Activities:

1 Underline the correct word.

- a I don't like that coat. The / A colour is horrible.
- b He doesn't like going to see the / a dentist.
- c She asked for the / a cup of coffee, but she got tea instead.
- d The / A laboratory is a place where scientific experiments are done.
- e I don't believe he's the / a policeman, he looks too young!
- f She is a / an intelligent woman.
- g I went to the / a bank today and they said I didn't have any money!
- h Who left the / a door open?
- i A / An hotel is more expensive than a / an youth hostel.
- j The / A film starts at half past seven.

2 Choose the correct form, A, B or C, to complete the sentence.

- a If you want to be healthier, think carefully about B you eat.
A food B the food C a food
- b If you don't enjoy _____, do something else.
A the exercise B an exercise C exercise
- c Try learning _____
A a new sport B new sport C the new sport
- d Sometimes the food you eat is less important than _____.
A food you don't eat B a food you don't eat C the food you don't eat
- e Do you eat enough _____?
A fruit and vegetables B the fruit and vegetables C fruit and the vegetables?
- f There is a saying, '_____ a day keeps the doctor away.'
A The apple B A apple C An apple
- g _____ chocolate cake should only be eaten occasionally.
A The piece of B Piece of C A piece of
- h Stress also makes _____ unhealthy.
A the people B people C a people
- i If you've had _____, try and do something nice for yourself.
A the bad day B bad day C a bad day
- j You could visit a friend or go to _____.
A cinema B the cinema C a cinema

3 Complete the text with *a / an* or *the*.

Memo checklist

a The word *memo* is short for *memorandum* and it means b a note to help as c a reminder.

It is only used within d a business and so there is no need for e a full external address of f a person you are sending it to. However, you might need to show g a internal office address, eg room number and building.

There are usually just spaces for h a names of the person sending and the person receiving i a memo. However, copies might be sent to other people in j a company for reference.

The subject is clear from k a heading and l a text is brief.

There is no formal signature. Sometimes m a originator will sign their name freehand at n a bottom.

Business letter checklist

o a language used in p a business letter tends to be formal eg 'We regret to inform you ...'

q a letterhead includes r a full address and telephone number of s a business.

t a address of u a recipient is also included in full on v a left-hand side above w a text.

Everything is left justified (starts at x a left-hand edge) except y a letterhead.

Letters starting 'Dear Sir' end in 'Yours faithfully'. If you start with z a name of the person you are writing to, for example 'Dear Mr Brown', you end i a letter with 'Yours sincerely'.

2 a date and any reference number are shown at 3 a top of 4 a letter.

science

4 Complete the text with *a / an*, *the* or leave blank for zero article.



Energy

a - waves are vibrations that transfer energy from place to place without b a matter (solid, liquid or gas) being transferred. For example, think of c a Mexican wave in d a crowd at e a football match. f a wave moves around g a stadium, while each spectator stays in their seat, only moving up then down when it's their turn.

Some waves must travel through h a substance. This substance is known as i a medium, and it can be solid, liquid or gas. j a sound waves and seismic waves are like this. As the waves travel through it, k a medium vibrates.

Other waves do not need to travel through l a substance. They may be able to travel through m a medium, but they do not have to. n a visible light, infrared rays, and microwaves are like this. They can travel through o a empty space.

5 Complete the text with *a / an, the* or leave blank for zero article.

Glaciers

Most of a the world's glaciers are found near
b the Poles, but c some glaciers exist on all
of d the world's continents. e These glaciers
need f a special kind of climate. Most are found
in g the areas of high snowfall in winter and cool
temperatures in summer. These weather conditions ensure that
h the snow that falls in the winter isn't lost by
i the melting, or j the evaporation in summer.
Such conditions typically occur in polar and high alpine regions. There are two main types of
k glaciers: l valley glaciers and m continental glaciers or ice sheets.
n These glaciers depend on o snow or p freezing rain to survive. In Antarctica,
for example, although q the temperature is low, there is little snow or rain, and this causes r glaciers there to grow very slowly.

A glacier forms when s snow builds up over time, turns to t ice, and begins to flow
outwards and downwards because of u the pressure of its own weight. v buried layers
slowly grow together to form a thickened mass of w ice. x the thickness of y glacial ice usually makes it seem a little blue in colour.



GLOSSARY

6 Complete each sentence with *the, a / an* or zero article.

- Last week at school we learned how to make a barometer.
- This is a cardboard which we used to make our barometer.
- And this is a bottle we used. We attached the cardboard to it.
- We made a measuring scale and attached it to the side of the bottle.
- This is a bowl we also used as part of our barometer.
We filled the bowl with water, and filled the bottle three quarters full,
and then turned the bottle upside down in the bowl.
- The pressure of air has an interesting effect on the water you put
in the bowl.
- The pressure makes the water in the bottle rise.
- We used a measuring scale on the side of the bottle to measure
the air pressure.

